Teacher Facilitation Insert

Reading Level D (Grade 4)

S3 CH05 — The Potter's Valley

Season 3: Makers and Creators

Timing for Level D

Phase	Duration	Key Activity
Launch	5 min	Vocabulary with morphology and prediction
Explore	10 min	Episode viewing with open prompts + reflection
Apply	20 min	Reading passage + 5 comprehension questions + vocabulary analysis
Practice	12 min	Analytical paragraph + extension task
Share	5 min	Question exchange + portfolio
Total	**52 min**	

Materials Checklist

- ☐ Episode queued or Read-Aloud Backup ready
- ☐ Vocabulary word cards visible to all students
- ☐ Student packs (one per student)
- ☐ Pencils and erasers
- ☐ Accountable talk stems posted on board

Facilitation Notes for Level D

Launch: Students predict definitions using morphology before episode. Introduce 6th vocabulary word (technique).
Explore: Students write independently using open prompts. After episode, discuss prediction accuracy and connection between patience and skill.

Chapter 5: The Potter's Valley

Reading Level D • Season 3: Makers and Creators

L — Launch: Vocabulary

Advanced Vocabulary Journal

Before the episode, use morphology to predict each word's meaning. After the episode, write the revised definition.

Word	Prediction (before episode)	Revised Definition (after)
kiln (KIL-n)		
vessel (VES-sel)		
symmetry (SIM-muh-tree)		
patient (PAY-shent)		
craft (KRAFT)		
technique (tek-NEEK)		

Morphology Analysis

Word	Root/Origin	Prefix/Suffix	Meaning Connection
symmetry	Greek: *syn* (together) + *metron* (measure)	-y (noun)	

E — Explore: Episode Viewing

Listening Guide

Write your thoughts at each pause point.

Pause 1

What did you notice when the Potter explained how to work with clay?

_____

_____

Pause 2

Why do you think Celeste says "center yourself first"?

_____

_____

Pause 3

What makes pulling up the clay so difficult?

_____

_____

After the episode:

Was your prediction about the vocabulary words correct?

_____

A — Apply: Reading

The Ancient Craft of Oaxacan Pottery

Read independently. As you read, think about how the author develops the idea that mastery requires deliberate practice.

In the villages of Oaxaca, Mexico, potters have practiced the ancient **craft** of black clay pottery for over two thousand years. Unlike ordinary brown or red clay, Oaxacan black clay comes from specific deposits in the valley. This pottery tradition demonstrates how deliberate practice and **patient** attention create mastery.

Before creating anything, a potter must prepare the clay through wedging. The potter pushes, folds, and kneads the clay hundreds of times. This process eliminates air pockets that would cause the clay to explode when exposed to the intense heat of the **kiln**. Proper wedging requires physical strength and concentration. Even experienced potters wedge for twenty to thirty minutes before beginning their work.

Centering the clay on the spinning wheel demands both **symmetry** and balance. The potter's wet hands apply gentle pressure while the wheel rotates. The wobbling lump gradually becomes perfectly centered. This step cannot be rushed. If the clay is not centered with precision, everything that follows will fail. The centered clay creates a foundation for the **vessel** to come.

CA CCSS for ELA/Literacy: RI.4.1, RI.4.4

Once centered, the potter opens the clay and pulls the walls upward with careful fingers. The thickness must remain consistent. The shape must maintain balance. Oaxacan potters create bowls, jars, and decorative figures using **techniques** passed down through generations.

After shaping, each piece dries slowly in the shade for three to seven days. Rushing this step causes cracking. When fully dry, vessels enter the kiln, which reaches temperatures between 1,500 and 1,800 degrees Fahrenheit. The firing process transforms soft clay into permanent pottery through chemical changes that can never be reversed. This transformation represents the culmination of patience, skill, and respect for the craft.

> **Footnote:**
> *Wedging:* A technique for kneading clay to remove air bubbles and create uniform consistency
> *Centering:* The process of stabilizing clay on a spinning wheel before shaping

A — Apply: Comprehension

Understanding the Text

Answer each question with text evidence and analytical thinking.

1. According to the passage, what makes Oaxacan black clay pottery unique?

A) It is made faster than other pottery
B) The clay comes from specific deposits in the valley
C) It does not require a kiln
D) It is easier to shape than other types of clay

My answer: _____

2. Why must potters wedge the clay for twenty to thirty minutes?

A) To make the clay colorful
B) To eliminate air pockets that could cause explosions
C) To cool the clay down
D) To make the clay dry faster

My answer: _____

3. Find a quote from the passage that shows centering clay requires precision. Write the quote and explain why it matters.

Quote:

_____

Why it matters:

_____

_____

4. What does the author want you to understand about the relationship between patience and mastery in pottery?

_____

_____

_____

A — Apply: Vocabulary Analysis

Advanced Vocabulary Practice

Demonstrate deep understanding of word relationships and origins.

Word Relationships

1. symmetry

Synonym: _____

Antonym: _____

Original sentence:

_____

2. patient

Synonym: _____

Antonym: _____

Original sentence:

_____

3. craft

Synonym: _____

Antonym: _____

Original sentence:

_____

4. vessel

Synonym: _____

Antonym: _____

Original sentence:

_____

Greek/Latin Root Analysis

1. technique comes from Greek *techne* (art, skill). What other English words share this root?

P — Practice: Written Response

Analytical Writing

Write a structured analytical paragraph. Use evidence from both the episode and the reading passage.

Prompt: Explain how patience functions as a skill. Use evidence from both the episode and the reading passage.

Structure your response:

- **Claim:** State your main idea about how patience functions as a skill
- **Evidence 1:** Example from episode or passage
- **Evidence 2:** Different example from episode or passage
- **Closing:** Explain why this matters

CA CCSS for ELA/Literacy: W.4.1, W.4.2

P — Practice: Extension

Extension Task

This is optional. Complete if you have time or take home to finish.

Compare and Contrast:
Compare how Celeste teaches to how a teacher in your school teaches. What is similar? What is different? Write 3-5 sentences.

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

S — Share: Question Exchange

My Question

Before discussion, write a question. After discussion, reflect on what you learned.

Before discussion: Write one question you have about pottery or the passage.

_____

_____

_____

After discussion: What did you learn from your partner's answer?

_____

_____

_____

_____

CA CCSS for ELA/Literacy: SL.4.1, SL.4.4

MY LEARNING JOURNAL

Season 3: Makers and Creators
Chapter 5: The Potter's Valley

Name: _____ Date: _____

S — Share: Portfolio

My Reflection

What did you learn about patience, craft, or mastery today?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

How I Did Today

1	2	3	4
I'm just starting	I'm getting there	I've got this	I can teach someone

Circle your rating: 1 2 3 4

I want to get better at:

_____

_____